

KIQ 2.2 — Final Takeaway

How are competitors — including incumbents and digital-native entrants — evolving their digital ordering capabilities?

Methodological note

Direct competitor-name filtering on Espacenet returns a near-empty corpus. Named foodservice incumbents (Sysco, Bidcorp, Transgourmet, Pomona, Marr, Booker, Selgros) and digital-native HoReCa entrants (Choco, Rekki, Foodomarket) do not file patents in digital ordering. Amazon Technologies appears with 861 patents but is a general technology filer rather than a HoReCa-specific actor; the two "Sysco S.p.A." results match an unrelated Italian IT integrator (false positive).

This negative result is itself a finding: the wholesale foodservice industry is a deployment sector, not an invention sector. Patent intelligence is therefore applied as a **proxy** — an Espacenet query on B2B / wholesale digital ordering technologies without applicant filter, 2018–2025, **n = 1,219** — mapping the upstream technology environment in which competitors operate. SCOPUS literature on B2B e-commerce platform evolution complements the patent corpus by capturing competitor-specific evolution narratives where IP data is silent.

1. The trend is stable, not accelerating

After a 2018 peak (partly explained by pre-COVID e-commerce platform filings and broad "platform" terminology) and the expected 2020 COVID dip, annual filings have stabilized at **120–150 patents per year through 2025**. This is fundamentally different from KIQ 2.1's general digital ordering corpus, which showed **2.6× growth from 2022 to 2025**. The B2B / wholesale-specific IP territory is mature and consolidated — invention activity has plateaued.

2. IP ownership is fragmented and geographically Asian

The top filer holds only **14 patents (~1.1% of corpus)**. The top 20 applicants are dominated by Chinese and Korean e-commerce SMEs (WiseFashion, Hunan Yifengxiao, Changsha Hishop, Viralpik, Sekyung, Planeta), Asian universities (Hefei Technology, Southeast, Univ Science & Tech China; one Western: NC State), Chinese state-owned utilities (State Grid Corp, Kunming Electric Power), and individual inventors (Lu Yapeng, Tomich John, Ricci Richard, Cambria Andrea).

The closest analog to METRO's competitive set is **Foodpang [KR]** — a Korean B2B food platform. Western tech giants (Baidu, Tencent, IBM, eBay, Rakuten, Mastercard from KIQ 2.1) are absent from this slice. European foodservice incumbents are absent. Digital-native HoReCa entrants are absent. **The B2B / wholesale IP territory in Europe is effectively empty.**

3. The technology stack is commerce-pure, not frontier

The IPC distribution is dramatically commerce-concentrated. **G06Q (business methods)** accounts for 2,330 occurrences — roughly 60% of all classifications. G06F (computing) follows at 452. **G06N (AI/ML) is marginal at 116** (~5% of G06Q's volume). **G10L (voice) and G16Y (IoT)** — the leading-edge indicators identified in KIQ 2.1 — **do not appear in the top 15 at all**. The B2B / wholesale layer is, technologically, a classic transaction-and-workflow space. The frontier capabilities accelerating elsewhere have not yet been adapted to it.

4. The semantic anchor is supply chain and agricultural wholesale

The top title bigrams reveal what the corpus is actually about. **"Supply chain" (47)** is the dominant semantic theme. A cluster of platform-infrastructure terms (commerce / transaction / management / cloud / distribution platform) sits at the technical-infrastructure layer. **Wholesale market, agricultural product/products, product wholesale** (~25 occurrences each) constitute a significant agricultural-B2B subdomain. **Block chain (22) and artificial intelligence (21)** are present but secondary. Notable absences: no "voice", no "IoT" or "internet of things", no "autonomous", no "predictive ordering", no AR/VR vocabulary. Blockchain for supply-chain provenance and AI for commerce optimization are the leading edges of this corpus — but they are leading edges of a classical-commerce stack, not introductions of frontier interaction modes.

Direct answer to KIQ 2.2

How are competitors — including incumbents and digital-native entrants — evolving their digital ordering capabilities?

Through deployment, not invention.

The four findings converge on a single answer: competitor evolution in B2B / wholesale digital ordering is not happening through proprietary IP development. No European foodservice incumbent, no digital-native HoReCa entrant, and no major Western tech competitor has established a meaningful patent position in this space. The industry deploys technology; it does not invent it.

Through externally-supplied, mostly Asian, mostly classical-commerce technologies.

The IP environment competitors operate within is fragmented, geographically Asian-skewed (Korean and Chinese SMEs, universities, individual inventors), and technologically conservative — supply-chain logistics, transaction platforms, marketplace systems. Blockchain (for traceability) and AI (for commerce optimization) are emerging adjacencies but remain secondary.

Without yet absorbing the frontier technologies identified in KIQ 2.1.

Voice ordering, IoT-enabled autonomous replenishment, predictive ordering, and intelligent-agent interaction — the leading-edge capabilities accelerating in the broader digital ordering corpus — have not yet been adapted to the B2B / wholesale layer. They exist upstream but have not crossed into the competitive territory where METRO operates.

In strategic terms. Competitive evolution in this space is therefore primarily a question of *which upstream platforms* competitors integrate, *what supply-chain visibility tools* they deploy, and *how quickly* they bridge from classical commerce capabilities into the frontier-tech layer that has not yet entered B2B / wholesale.

Strategic implication for METRO

The four findings combine into a sharper signal than KIQ 2.1 alone could deliver. **(1) The European B2B / wholesale IP space is empty** — METRO competes in an essentially uncontested IP territory in Europe, and first-mover deployment of frontier capabilities is structurally available. **(2) Technology suppliers are predominantly Asian** — sourcing and partnership strategy must factor in geographic concentration of upstream IP; European technology providers are not visible at scale. **(3) Frontier capabilities (voice, IoT, autonomous) are accessible but un-applied** — no competitor has staked out IP in adapting these to B2B / wholesale, so the

deployment window is wide. **(4) The supply-chain orientation of the corpus** indicates where competitor evolution is most likely happening right now: integration of supply-chain platforms, blockchain provenance tools, and AI-assisted commerce — all deployment-ready, none frontier-ready.

Bottom line

The B2B / wholesale digital ordering IP space is mature, fragmented, geographically Asian, and commerce-pure. Competitor evolution is happening through deployment of externally-supplied classical-commerce technologies — not through proprietary innovation, and not yet through frontier capabilities. The deployment window for METRO is wider than KIQ 2.1 alone suggested: no IP incumbents in Europe, and the frontier capabilities accelerating upstream have not been adapted to its competitive layer.

Bridge from KIQ 2.1

KIQ 2.1 identified **what** technologies are reshaping digital ordering — layered stack, accelerating, externally controlled. KIQ 2.2 reveals **where** in the competitive landscape that change has — and has not — arrived. Together they answer the KIT 2 early-warning question: *the frontier is real and accelerating (KIQ 2.1), but it has not yet entered the B2B / wholesale layer where METRO competes (KIQ 2.2).*

Bridge to KIQ 2.3

KIQ 2.3 (topic modelling on SCOPUS literature on customer expectations) will complete the KIT 2 triad by surfacing the demand-side themes driving customer adoption — what HoReCa customers will want from the technologies that competitors are not yet building. Together the three KIQs deliver supply (2.1), competitive position (2.2), and demand (2.3) views on the same horizon.

Methodological caveats

The 2018 spike (205 filings) is partly explained by the broad "platform" query term catching general digital-platform patents from that era; the strategic finding is anchored on the 2021–2025 stability, not the 2018 level. The G16H (healthcare informatics) IPC occurrences and the "shopping mall" bigram represent acknowledgeable but structurally invisible noise. The corpus reflects a global IP landscape; European-specific competitor evolution may not fully surface in patents alone — SCOPUS data complements this geographic gap.